

metroPLUS THE  HINDU

June - August: Rolling meadows @ Miyar Valley

Located deep within the Lahaul region near Udaipur in Himachal Pradesh, Miyar Valley offers trekkers a glimpse of a lesser-known Himachal. The trek begins at around 12,000 feet and remains largely between 12,000 and 13,000 feet throughout. Unlike Hampta Pass, where the landscape changes dramatically, Miyar Valley is defined by its vastness and continuity, says Ravi Ranjan, chief of experience and safety, Indiahikes. “The valley is considerably wider than most Himalayan valleys in Himachal and remains largely dry because it lies on the leeward side of the Pir Panjal range, which divides the Kullu valley from the Lahaul valley,” he says.

What makes Miyar Valley unique is the absence of dense vegetation. “Unlike many Himalayan valleys that are lined with forests, rhododendrons, or alpine vegetation, Miyar’s landscape is dominated by open grasslands, shrubs, and rocky terrain. Towering snow-clad peaks rise on both sides of the valley, while numerous streams and waterfalls descend from glaciers high above,” says Ravi, adding that this trek is easy on the legs when compared to other treks in Lahaul-Spiti, Pin Bhaba Pass, Kanamo Peak, for



SANTHOSH GOVINDARAJULU

instance. As the valley lies in a relatively drier region of Lahaul, the flowers are generally less conspicuous than those found in Hampta Pass. Having said that, dominant species include Himalayan bistort and Himalayan geranium, with extensive patches of yellow flowering plants appearing across the grasslands. “Marsh marigolds create beautiful yellow highlights within the meadows, while the Himalayan blue poppy can occasionally be found in some locations.”

Another defining aspect of the Miyar Valley is its cultural character, as the region carries a strong Buddhist influence. This is reflected in the presence of many gompas and cultural landmarks along the trek’s route. “Because the altitude gain is gradual and the trail involves very little strenuous climbing, the experience feels less like a mountain ascent and more like a journey through a vast natural sanctuary.”

Highlights include the meadows of Gompa, the grasslands and water channels around Palpu, and the crystal-clear glacial lakes at the Miyar River’s origins. Trekkers are offered accommodation, meals, essential camping gear, safety gear, a trek leader, and local guides.

₹14,950 plus GST for a week-long trek. Details on indiahikes.com

The hills are alive

CONTINUED FROM
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RAVI RANJAN

June - September: Wildflowers @ Hampta Pass

In Himachal Pradesh’s Kullu-Manali region, Indiahikes offers several treks to Chandrakhani Pass, the Chandrabhaga glaciers trek, and Hampta Pass. The latter, in particular, “is one of the country’s most beautiful crossover treks,” says Ravi Ranjan.

Starting from the lush green valleys near Manali, he explains that the trail gradually climbs to the Hampta Pass at around 14,000 feet before descending into the starkly different landscapes of Lahaul. “On one side, trekkers experience dense forests. On the other side lies an arid, rugged landscape almost completely devoid of vegetation. Witnessing this sudden shift in geography and ecology over the course of a trek is a remarkable experience,” he shares.

From mid-July onward, Ravi explains how the valley turns into a “spectacular alpine flower garden” with the diversity of flowers varying with altitude, terrain, and the timing of the monsoon. “One of the most striking flowers is the Himalayan bistort. These pink flower spikes carpet entire meadows, especially around the campsites of Jobra, Jwara, and Balu Ka Ghera.” Other prominent species include the bright yellow Himalayan groundsel (Senecio), the blue-violet Himalayan geranium, and the delicate Himalayan anemone. “Among the most beautiful flowers found on the trail are the primroses.” The final campsite at Chatru is surrounded by barren mountains. “Hampta Pass offers a complete Himalayan experience – lush valleys, river trails and more.”

₹12,950 + GST for a six-day trek. Details on indiahikes.com



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

August: Kaas Plateau, Maharashtra

Come August, and Maharashtra’s ‘Valley of Flowers’ comes alive with over 170 species of wildflowers. Located 25 kilometres from the northern part of the Koyana Sanctuary, the Kaas Plateau is listed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site and is home to a range of butterflies, birds, and reptiles.

Randhir Jaya Naidu of Pune-based heritage travel outfit Deccan Drifts has been organising trips to the region, also known as Kas Pathar, since 2022.

Private vehicles drop visitors off at the designated parking area from where the Forest Department’s shuttle takes them to the entrance gates of the zones. “From the gates, you have to walk on pathways made on flat ground on top of the fossilised volcanic plateau.”

Randhir says Kaas Plateau has changed “a lot” since it received international attention with the UNESCO tag. “Crowds started coming in after that, and barricades and pathways were added. The number of blooms has dropped sharply since. Flowers bloom from mid-September, when the rains slow down, and stay till mid-October. Due to recent climate changes and rains continuing all through September, it has affected the flowering season,” he says, adding that people pluck flowers, litter the area with plastic, and walk on flower beds to take photos. “All these factors have hampered the growth rate. I have never seen Kaas Plateau like I did on my first visit ever again.”

₹2,400 per head. For bookings, call 9130641707.



June - August: Dzukou Valley, Nagaland

Khrieibu Zhasa’s fondest childhood memories were the winter treks she took with her family to Kohima’s Shürho peak. “There was a small rest house where we would make a pit stop. My parents would prepare lunch, while we cousins would make our way to the top of Shürho. Our knees would get wobbly on the trek down, and I remember my father would walk in front and hand me the other end of his walking stick and tell me to focus on the next step and sing along with him,” says Khrieibu, 38, managing director of travel outfit, Explore Nagaland.

Here, Khrieibu, along with her sister Nino Zhasa, offers custom tours of the Northeast and a range of flower treks. “The village youth has popularised many flower trails in the region via social media. Akule Potato (Kigwema) for beautiful hydrangeas in June and July, Mosen View Point in October-November for cosmos, to name a few. However, maintenance is a communal effort,” says Nino, the founder, adding that Japfu Peak (October-April) is great for rhododendron blooms. Located at an elevation of 3,048 metres, it takes trekkers five hours uphill and three hours downhill.

Khrieibu says the Dzukou Valley trek is open year-round, and the Dzukou lily is in full bloom from June to early August. This was launched by the duo in 2002 when Nino was hosting her first British visitors to Nagaland. Says Khrieibu, “Now, there’s a designated campsite where guests can register. We offer day hikes and overnight treks as well.”

All trails are customised. For bookings, call 9089948353, 8787396634

pick of the week



Bite the world

Your passport to sandwiches is here. Six ‘O’ One and The Leather Bar at THE Park Chennai are serving up Sandos Without Borders, a menu of gourmet sandwiches from across the globe. Expect Greek gyros, Tokyo-style chicken katsu, Venezuelan arepas, Cuban chicken, prawn melt and more, between freshly baked sourdough, focaccia, milk bread and corn bread. Till July 19, at The Leather Bar at THE Park, available daily from 12pm to 11.30pm.



Threads of Madurai

Celebrate Madurai’s timeless charm with Malli Kili, Anavila’s latest sari collection inspired by goddess Meenakshi, the iconic jasmine flower, and the beloved parrot of Tamil lore.

Expect handwoven linen and cotton-silk saris in reds, greens, and luminous whites. Also featured is Sheetal Zaveri by Vithaldas’ Devi sterling silver jewellery. On till July 14, 11am to 7.30pm, at Amethyst, Royapettah. Saris from ₹8,000; jewellery from ₹6,000 onwards.



Mindful shopping

Trade fast fashion for mindful shopping at The Maker’s Courtyard, a two-day pop-up featuring handcrafted offerings from Slowthreads, Studio Cadambari, The Kraft Faktor, and Aarika Jewellery.

Stay on for The Cost of Cheap panel discussion (July 11) and the Mend, Keep & Love mending workshop (July 12), for conversations on ethical consumption, and textile revival. At CP Art Centre, Mini Gallery, Alwarpet, from 11am to 8pm. Prices start at ₹300 onwards.

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By now, memorable walk-on moments have become something of a signature for four-time Grand Slam champion Naomi Osaka. Wimbledon this year has been no different.

The 28-year-old tennis player walked onto Centre Court for her first-round match at the start of the tournament, in an intricately designed all-white kimono-inspired garment worn over her Nike dress, that will no doubt, earn its place in the annals of tennis fashion.

After blitzing through the first round, Naomi spoke about her outfit to the press, stating that she was inspired by her culture and the ‘iconic kimono silhouette’, as well as Wimbledon’s strict dress code to adhere to white attire. O-ren Ishii played by Lucy Liu in *Kill Bill*, who makes an appearance in an all-white kimono also served as inspiration.

Behind this creation is Tokyo-based designer, Hana Yagi, who collaborated with creative director Marty Harper to bring this look to life.

“I was contacted by Marty Harper and from the very beginning, we had a clear direction: to respect Wimbledon’s all-white tradition while reinterpreting the structure and philosophy of traditional Japanese clothing within the context of contemporary sports,” she says.

Several conversations with Marty followed, and Hana



Game. Set. Style

Designer Hana Yagi on the craft and symbolism of Naomi Osaka’s kimono-inspired memorable Wimbledon walk-on ensemble

proposed using vintage shiromuku (a traditional all-white bridal kimono), kimono fabrics and tulle.

“The concept behind the look was to reinterpret the structure of the traditional Japanese kimono in a contemporary way. Rather than recreating a kimono as it is, I wanted to translate its structure, philosophy, and beauty into the language of sport,” Hana says. She adds, “Instead of treating tradition as something fixed, I see it as something that evolves through repeated deconstruction and reconstruction.”

All of this was done, while preserving elements such as the silhouette of the kimono sleeves and the ceremonial presence of the shiromuku. “It also needed to be lightweight and comfortable enough for Naomi to walk onto the court. It was equally important that the outfit could be put on and removed quickly,” she says. The finer details are equally eye-catching. Embroidered cranes and cherry blossoms embellish the kimono-inspired garment, while an obi belt, punctuated with bows, ties the look together. She donned a traditional kanzashi, or an

Naomi Osaka dons Hana Yagi’s kimono-inspired outfit. AP AND ADAM KUDEIMATI



ornamental hair pin featuring flowers as well.

When Naomi first drifted out onto the court, a vision in white, she also picked up her racquet and played a few shots to warm up; something Hana had to keep in mind when designing the outfit.

“Although it appears voluminous, I repeatedly experimented with different material combinations and construction techniques to achieve both lightness and a strong visual presence,” she said.

Hana’s use of a shiromuku and vintage fabrics for Naomi’s outfit

mirrors her design practice, which takes a creative approach to materials that are not typically experimented with.

She primarily works with vintage wedding dresses and shiromoku that have completed their ceremonial lives at wedding venues and photo studios, and then lie discarded. “Rather than erasing the time and memories they carry, I want to dismantle and reconstruct them so they can continue into a new story,” she says.

Her Sanguine Bride collection for instance, featured discarded wedding dresses which were then deconstructed and dyed red. British singer-songwriter Paris Paloma, most notably, donned an outfit from this collection during a stage performance.

“Old garments already contain stories. Who wore them? In what time and society were they made? Imagining those histories is, for me, an essential part of the creative process,” Hana explains.

Since Naomi’s appearance, Hana notes an increase in interest not just in similar pieces, but also in the ideas behind her work, and the way she approaches the materials she uses.

“More than simply presenting Japanese culture, I wanted to respect tradition while reinterpreting it within a contemporary context. It was a great honour to express that idea through Naomi Osaka’s Wimbledon look, and I also believe it became an opportunity for different cultures to meet and create something new together,” she adds.

(Clockwise from below) Trincas in Park Street, Kolkata; Usha Uthup performing then and now; and Anand Puri. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND R RAVINDRAN



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“Trincas is like home to me. It is my *mandir*, it is my *masjid*, it is my *girija*. It is my hallowed ground, really. I still feel a lump in my throat when I enter it. Trincas is my everything,” says legendary singer and Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri awardee Usha Uthup, with a reservoir of gratitude in her heart.

On July 19, some of this rich history will be brought back to life. As part of *The Hindu* Lit for Life Unplugged, Usha Uthup and historian Anand Puri, third-generation custodian of Trincas, will come together at the iconic Park Street institution for *When Park Street Sings: A Conversation on Music, Memory & Kolkata*.

Moderated by *The Hindu's* Associate Editor, Shonali Muthalaly, the evening will trace Usha Uthup's musical journey while revisiting the story of Trincas, Park Street, and a city that once made music every night of the week.

For nearly a century, generations have walked through Trincas carrying vastly different ambitions. Some came looking for music. A few arrived before they

became famous. Many left having witnessed history without quite realising it.

Industrialists shared tables with actors. Maharajas crossed paths with musicians. Indian and West Indian cricket legends unwound here after matches. A young Amitabh Bachchan walked through its doors before superstardom. So did Sharmila Tagore, Saira Banu, and Randhir Kapoor. One evening in the 1980s, members of the British rock band *The Who* wandered in and found the live band playing their own songs, unaware that the original band members were among the audience.

Usha remembers the time when Bengal's most acclaimed and loved actor Uttam Kumar walked in. “I didn't even know who Uttam Kumar was when I first arrived in Kolkata. On my second or third day at Trincas, he came to watch me perform. One of the musicians leaned over and said, “The crowd is going wild because that's Bengal's biggest star.” I remember thinking how incredibly debonair and handsome he looked,” recalls the singer.

For Anand, who has spent years researching his forthcoming book chronicling 100 years of Calcutta through



In tune with Trincas

Rediscover Park Street's musical legacy with Usha Uthup and Anand Puri at *The Hindu's* Lit for Life Unplugged in Kolkata

the story of Trincas, the restaurant is far more than a celebrated address on Park Street.

In the 1960s, Park Street had become what Anand calls, “the most exciting entertainment destination in India”. Every restaurant had a live band. Diners drifted from one venue to another, following the music as naturally as they followed dinner. Trincas stood at the centre of that constellation.

“It had the biggest dance floor. The talent selection was spot on,” Anand says. “The younger crowd, especially Anglo-Indian musicians, gathered there for morning and afternoon jam sessions. By



evening, the city's glitterati took over,” he adds.

Long before they became international names, performers such as Engelbert



Humperdinck then still performing as Arnold Dorsey and music producer Biddu Appaiah performed on the Trincas stage. Biddu would later go on to produce ‘Kung Fu Fighting’ before reshaping Indian pop through artistes including Nazia Hassan, Alisha Chinai, Shaan and Shweta Shetty.

In 1969, during a hotel association conference in Madras, Anand's grandfather watched a young singer named Usha Iyer perform. Convinced he had discovered an extraordinary voice, he returned to Calcutta and spoke to his business partner Ellis Joshua, who handled Trincas'

What to expect at Lit for Life Unplugged

- How a young Tamil singer from Mumbai became synonymous with Kolkata.
- Why Park Street became India's entertainment capital.
- The untold stories behind Trincas' century-long history.
- The making of Anand Puri's forthcoming book chronicling 100 years of Calcutta through Trincas.
- Why restaurants often become repositories of a city's memory.

music programming. Soon afterwards, an inland letter was sent inviting the young singer to Park Street. The rest belongs to Kolkata's cultural memory.

Anand believes Usha's arrival transformed the room almost overnight. “No one expected a sari-clad lady with a large bindi to sound like a Western crooner. The singers on Park Street usually wore gowns and evening dresses. Ushaji surprised everyone,” he says.

Soon there were queues stretching outside Trincas. Audiences came as much for her wit as for her unmistakable voice.

Recording memory

Anand has spent years working on the Trincas Timeline Project, an ongoing archive of anecdotes shared by former patrons scattered across the world.

His forthcoming book, which will be announced at the event, follows those stories across continents, tracing migrations from the Swiss Alps, Lahore, and Rangoon into Calcutta.

The conversation at the Lit for Life Unplugged event will also turn the pages of Usha Uthup's memoir, *The Queen of Indian Pop: The Authorised Biography of Usha Uthup*. Speaking of the book, published by Penguin Random House, Usha recalls, “It actually began as an interview I was supposed to do with journalist Vikas Kumar Jha. We started talking, and the interview became so interesting. At one point I wondered, “How can this remain just an interview?” That's when he suggested, “Let's make it a biography.” The book was originally written in Hindi and titled *Ullas Ki Naav*. We managed to draw out memories that had been deeply embedded in my mind, tucked away in forgotten corners. The English translation, *The Queen of Indian Pop*, was beautifully done by Srishti Jha.”

“When I revisit it now, my favourite chapters are the ones about my childhood. I remember spending afternoons with my brother, lying on the crook of a guava tree, reading comics. Another chapter I love is about making string for my brothers' kites,” outlines the singer.

Lit for Life Unplugged, part of The Hindu's Lit for Life festival, comes to Trincas on July 19 at 4.30pm. Entry is free with prior registration. Drinks and food are on you, the stories are on us. With just 100 seats available, register early and step into the room where Kolkata's soundtrack was once written.



To register, scan the QR code

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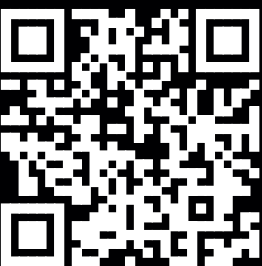
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LUXURY SALON & MAKEOVER STUDIO

(Clockwise from right) Clam chowder, oysters and fresh lobster on offer at Legal Sea Foods; the Boston skyline; buttery lobster rolls; a vintage photo of the Union Oyster House; and freshly shucked oysters from the Union Oyster House. HUGO GALDONES AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



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I first set out to eat a lobster roll. I am in chilly Boston, perfect weather for the city's other favourite food icon: clam chowder. On my obligatory visit to Harvard University, I rub the John Harvard statue boot for good luck and then set out on my mission.

I am rewarded almost immediately at Harvest, a cosy restaurant at Harvard square which celebrates New England farmers and purveyors. The space is cosy and deliberately old school, serving up bowls of comforting New England Clam chowder rich with potatoes, bacon and cream, all woven together with the freshness of leeks and celery.

Boston hosted seven matches for the FIFA World Cup 2026, including one of the quarter-finals. The games were played at Boston Stadium, historically known as Gillette Stadium. According to the stadium website, fans were able to buy fried chicken sandwiches, hot dogs, soft pretzels and even salads, fruit cups and veggies plates at their concession stands. However, for a proper taste of Boston, here is our guide.

Starting with my lobster roll.

Legal Sea Foods

We watch seagulls wrestling the wind from the large French windows at Legal Sea Food's flagship Harborside restaurant, which overlooks the city's scenic waterfront. As we enter the huge, sunlit space I am distracted by the expansive oyster bar, and we order a plate. They are briny, cool and satisfying, served on ice with a fat lemon wedge.

Beside clam chowder, the menu boasts lobster bisque, mussels served with garlic-butter broth, and New England clams (described as "sweet and petite"). I am on a mission though, and I focus on the rolls. Boston traditionally offers them in two ways. You can order them Maine style, where the meat is chilled and served with mayonnaise.

I am not strong enough to resist a warm buttered roll, however, so I

Boston on a bun

Fuel up on buttery lobster rolls and steaming clam chowder with a side of history, before venturing into the city's lesser-known neighbourhoods for vibrant ethnic cuisine

order the Connecticut version, where generous chunks of lobster glossy with butter are served on a just-toasted roll. The locally sourced lobster is excellent, and the hearty dish is intelligently built to let each flavour shine.

The Union Oyster House

We regally settle at the Kennedy Booth with oversized prawn cocktails. Designated a National Historic Landmark, The Union Oyster House is the oldest continually-operating restaurant and oyster bar in the United States. Housed in a Pre-Revolutionary building, it started serving food in 1826, then launched its iconic



semi-circular Oyster Bar in 1897 serving 'bench opened' oysters, freshly shucked for diners.

American presidents, including Franklin Roosevelt, John F Kennedy and Bill Clinton, have dined here.

Kennedy, who visited the Oyster House every Sunday at noon when he was in Boston, sat at number 18, the booth I am seated at.

We order cups of steaming clam chowder (of course) served with fluffy, crumbly cornbread, still fragrant from the oven. Then, following in JFK's footsteps, get a round of classic Daiquiris.

John Paul, the manager who tells us how he worked his way up from a bus boy at the restaurant over 11 years, also introduces us to Sam Adams Colonial ale, specially curated for Oyster House. Our prawn cocktail is simple but dramatic, starring huge, juicy prawns posed beside crisp lettuce. We soak in the atmosphere as we eat: polished floors, wood-panelled walls and a large stuffed lobster, weighing 44 pounds.

"The restaurant is a living museum," says John, saying they have a capacity of 500 diners at a time, and are always packed. Their cornbread, made fresh every day, is everyone's favourite order and he says, "We go through hundreds and hundreds of pounds of it every day," adding with a laugh, "I gained about 20 pounds when I started working here."



mid-century modern detailing and an addictive spicy lobster Capellini.

Noticing practically every table ordering bowls of the Maine lobster tangled in delicate angel hair pasta, and a decadent sauce of tomato, cream and Calabrian chilli, we follow suit. Secondi also involves a hearty Macaroni with Wild Boar Ragu topped with pleasingly salty pecorino. Since it is Sunday brunch, we also order Florentine Benedicts topped with curls of prosciutto, hollandaise, spinach and perfectly poached eggs.

Although Contessa boasts signature Italian and French wines, from Piedmont, Tuscany, Bordeaux, and Burgundy, I cannot resist the call of their chilled Martinis.

They do three, and do them well: A Vesper, with gin, vodka and cocchi americano. The Classic, with gin, vermouth and bitters, and a deliciously dirty version with olive brine.

Dessert is fluffy Panettone French Toast, and I sink back into a couch as comfortable as a hug. Football fans will find plenty of excitement inside the stadium. I hope they also discover the pleasure of a generously buttered lobster roll, oysters on ice, and the stories that shaped America's Cradle of Liberty.

The writer was in Boston, on invitation from Brand USA

An insider's guide to Boston Chef Carl Dooley, Mooncusser

What's your go-to Boston comfort food – and where's the best place to get it?

Singh's Roti Shop in Dorchester – it's an amazing spot for Trinidad carry-out. They have the best goat curry and the Doubles are awesome. It is super delicious and a great representative for the Caribbean population here in Boston.

What's one thing first-time visitors usually get wrong about the city?

Maybe visitors come here for history, but then hopefully they realise the innovation, the arts, and definitely the food scene while here.

Is there a local ingredient you wish more people paid attention to?

Pupusas! We have a large Salvadorian population here in the city – and La Reina in East Boston is amazing. I always recommend to my friends and guests that they go visit East Boston, try some of the delicious Pupusas at La Reina, and then walk the harbourfront.

What is one under-rated Boston experience visitors should not miss?

I recommend to friends and visitors alike – go rent a Blue Bike and ride along the Charles River. Go from Esplanade and Back Bay over to the Mass. Ave Bridge and head into Cambridge for lunch at Central Square.

Which neighbourhood do tourists tend to overlook but really should spend more time at?

Allston. Allston has great dive bars, awesome Korean BBQ, and some super small independent music places. Catch a show at the Brighton Music Hall – it always has great shows. The neighbourhood has a bit of a Brooklyn vibe which is cool.

Chef Carl Dooley is recognised nationally for his creative take on fresh seasonal New England ingredients viewed through a global lens.



Michelin has listed Mooncusser as one of its recommended restaurants, and Dooley is a multiple James Beard Foundation nominee, a Top Chef Top Five Finalist, and Eater Boston Chef of the Year.



Flavours of Punjab

Try flavours of Punjab as Chef Deepa Arora brings an authentic Amritsari breakfast to Chennai with her new menu at The Kitchen by Chef Deepa. Dig into hearty aloo parathas, paneer parathas, Amritsari kulchas, puri with aloo loungi, and chole bhature, paired with refreshing Punjabi sweet lassi, masala chaach, or Amritsari shikanjeevi.

End on a sweet note with Lahori phirnee, saffron suji halwa, or jamun rabri. Every dish is inspired by recipes from Chef Deepa's hometown of Amritsar. Available at, The Kitchen by Chef Deepa, Taramani (also on Swiggy and Zomato). For orders call 9363544123.

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Raising a Glass to Chennai's Maritime Past



Few bars are remembered solely for what they serve; the truly memorable ones leave guests with a story. At The Library Bar, The Leela Palace Chennai, history and hospitality come together through Tales of Trade, an immersive cocktail and dining experience inspired by Chennai's legacy as one of the Indian Ocean's great maritime trading ports. Drawing from centuries of cultural exchange along the Coromandel Coast, the experience transforms the city's trading past into a contemporary narrative. The bar's intimate library setting, lined with books, artefacts and warm, understated interiors, evokes the spirit of discovery that once defined Chennai's shores. At the heart of the experience is The Prose of Pours, a cocktail programme that reimagines historic trade ingredients;

spices, botanicals and rare aromatics, through modern mixology. Complementing it is Tasting Chapters, a thoughtfully curated menu inspired by coastal cuisines and the movement of flavours across continents. The storytelling extends beyond the glass. Guests are welcomed with The Welcome Ledger, invited to personalise cocktails through The Merchant's Chest, and conclude their evening with Message in a Bottle, a signature serve paired with a keepsake recounting an overlooked chapter of Chennai's maritime history. As daylight fades, the space evolves into The Listening Room, where vinyl records, live music and carefully curated performances lend an effortless rhythm to the evening. Open until 1 a.m., The Library Bar offers more than an evening out, it presents an invitation to experience Chennai's past through flavour, conversation and craftsmanship, one thoughtfully composed pour at a time.



Hindi

Alia Bhatt
fires up a stale
spectacle



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The YRF Spy Universe is running out of breathing room. What started as a focused story about one legendary agent has morphed into a crowded superhero-style playground where every major Bollywood star needs their own badge. After much delay, this week, Alia Bhatt jumps into the fray to bring some gender parity to a world ruled by men for over a decade.

Traditionally, in spy movies, female characters were usually romantic interests, sidekicks, or spies who still needed the male hero to handle the big boss. Here, Alia is Alpha unto herself, not standing in anyone's shadow.

She injects a wicked sense of personality in Sita, a blend of snark and sass to hide the emotional vulnerability of an orphan deep down. Sita is an isolated survivor, but Alia brings the confidence of a predator to Sita. The problem is that there is hardly any freshness in the story, and Alia struggles to keep it from feeling like a comic strip spread over two hours. Writers Uday Chopra, Shridhar Raghavan, and Ishita Moitra blend ancient Indian mythology with Marvel flicks, but it ultimately feels like an unoriginal mashup. A jingoistic man in uniform, Fateh (Bobby Deol), launches a secret plan to create super soldiers with the help of a doctor (Dibyendu Bhattacharya) by injecting a serum that he named Alpha. The experiment goes awry, and Fateh is demoted. However, in between, his mentor Kaul (Anil Kapoor) injects it into the bloodstream of his pregnant wife (Dia Mirza) to save her from congenital heart disease. She could not be saved, but the chemical alters the daughter's genes. Fateh misleads Kaul, takes ownership of the girl, and raises her as a killing machine called Sita.

The promotional campaign essentially gave away the entire puzzle, leaving the cross-border Pakistan connection as the only real mystery left for the theatre. And it has become a permanent checkbox on the Bollywood spy-thriller shopping list. Overall, one feels the writing department definitely needs a massive dose of Alpha serum to inject some energy, depth, and originality into the franchise. Sharvari matches Alia's intensity in dramatic and combat scenes, making you believe the girls are cut from the same genetic material. Their dynamics work well, but the makers do not delve into it and quickly return to gunshots and choppers.

While the film belongs to its leading ladies, the solid presence of Bobby and Anil cannot be understated. Their commitment and intensity provide enough dramatic weight to keep a shallow, derivative script afloat for those who marvel at spectacle rather than storytelling.

Alpha is currently running in theatres.



The anatomy of State violence

Diljit Dosanjh shines as a solitary lamp whose conviction outlasts the darkest night in this moving tribute to social activist Jaswant Singh Khalra

Hindi

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A quiet hymn sung for the thousands of names in Punjab that the State machinery tried to wipe during the insurgency, director Honey Trehan tells the story of a God-fearing, resilient man who looked at a landscape of fear and chose not to look away.

Armed with the fragile pages of municipal logs and the calculated weights of cremation firewood, he resurrects the disappeared, meticulously piecing together a forensic paper trail that strips away the senior police leadership's complicity. For the uninitiated, *Satluj* (originally titled *Panjab 95*) chronicles the true-life crusade of social activist Jaswant Singh Khalra (Diljit Dosanjh), who risked his life to uncover thousands of secrets behind the State-sanctioned extrajudicial cremations in the 1990s when Punjab was on the boil.

Coming at a time when human rights are viewed skeptically, and activism is routinely branded a threat to national security, *Satluj* arrives not just as a period drama, but as a fearless, contemporary warning. Caught in the cobwebs of the Central Board of Film Certification for years, it is the story of a terrifying dark, but more than that, it is the story of a solitary candle that refused to be blown out by the winds of systemic tyranny in a democracy.

Years after Gulzar looked at the 'other side' through the eyes of the rebel in the hideout in *Maachis*, Trehan views the other side through the eyes of the citizen activist, fighting not for a political ideology but for basic human rights and the preservation of memory.

The lens of KU Mohanan's unflinching camera captures the hypnotic effect of unresolved grief as we watch the humble

Satluj

Director: Honey Trehan

Cast: Diljit Dosanjh, Geetika Vidya Ohlyan, Suvinder Vicky, Kanwaljeet Singh, SM Zaheer

Synopsis: The film chronicles the real-life human rights crusade of Jaswant Singh Khalra, who risks his family's safety to uncover thousands of secrets behind the State-sanctioned extrajudicial killings in 1990s Punjab.



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bank manager transform into a collector of ghosts after his friend Kirpal disappears in thin air and his mother Gurpej loses her mind to the agonising void of waiting. Jaswant knocks at the doors of the system, but meets deafening silence and a not-so-unspoken warning that his ledger of the dead could easily include his own name next.

SSP Sugga (Suvinder Vicky) emerges as the symbol of State impunity, having turned murder into a mundane routine in the name of national security. Working under the cover of the imposing DGP Bitta (Kanwaljeet Singh), the film uses Vicky's casual demeanour to show that the system had normalised mass murder into a standard administrative operation to secure promotions and institutional favour. Amidst the maelstrom, the unspoken agreement between Jaswant and his wife Paramjeet (Geetika Vidya Ohlyan) serves as the film's psychological anchor. Her tears stem from a terrifying conflict. She deeply respects his moral righteousness, but is terrified of the price.

Having Kanwaljeet Singh and SM Zaheer on screen provides a sense of eerie continuity. For audiences like me who remember the haunting impact of *Maachis* in theatres, watching Singh and Zaheer in *Satluj* as symbols of the system all over again acts as a subconscious reminder that this is the same soil, the same conflict, and the same unresolved generational trauma, just viewed from a different vantage point.

Between the lines, the film serves as a timeless warning about how the biggest democracies use the ruse of national security to vilify whistleblowers and cover up systemic atrocities. Without letting his grip slip from the narrative, Trehan exposes this rhetoric of dehumanisation. When Jaswant Singh exposes the paper trail, DGP Bitta, who seems to be based on the late KPS Gill, a deeply polarising figure, instantly dismisses his human rights plea as attention-seeking gimmicks fuelled by foreign powers.

By introducing an upright,

constitutional investigator in the form of Samudra Singh (Arjun Rampal is efficient), the script avoids painting the entire Indian State machinery with a single, villainous brush. In a moving sequence, Samudra reminds a rogue cop that the State cannot forever use the trauma of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots and cross-border militancy to justify the planned murder of thousands of civilians.

Trehan frames the critique of the system not as an anti-State diatribe, but as a defence of the rule of law, as Jaswant proves from the bureaucratic files that the police force had stopped distinguishing between actual militants and ordinary, innocent civilians for promotions and profiteering. Like Gulzar, he shows that citizens are like matchsticks that ignite when pushed too far by systemic cruelty, as he recreates the assassination of CM Beant Singh as the tipping point.

Despite running over 160 minutes, narrative tension doesn't slacken. The runtime feels earned as the screenplay undergoes mutation from an immersive procedural to a high-stakes thriller with an unexpected layer of dark humour. It ensures that despite gravity, the film never succumbs to tedious pacing.

Diljit delivers a restrained, internalised performance. They might not give him big box-office numbers, but serious, grounded dramatic roles uncover the absolute best of his acting craft. His expressive eyes, soft voice and pauses carry a profound gravity that louder, comedic performances often mask. Vicky proves to be a perfect dark foil to Diljit, who plays Sugga as an arrogant career bureaucrat who knows he has the might of the State apparatus behind him. *Satluj* is a significant document that deserves your attention not just as an archive for the unmournd but also as a vital mirror held up to the machinery of modern democracies.

Satluj was taken down two days after its premiere on July 3, following a Government directive.

Double the fun, same old pitfalls

Tamil

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When director Chella Ayyavu's *Gatta Kusthi* released in 2022, it turned out to be quite a successful fixture for both Vishnuu Vishal and Aishwarya Lekshmi, becoming a hit that furthered its momentum on post-theatrical streaming. It had pockets of fun and a quirky onliner, however, at the end of the day, it was a highly regressive one-trick-wonder masquerading as a progressive film standing up for women. So you must imagine the kind of expectations I would have set for the sequel, releasing four years later.

However, I am to report with surprise that *Gatta Kusthi 2* not only betters its predecessor but also comes close – just about – to redeeming the problems in the first film. Six years after the events of the first film, Veera (Vishnuu) is no longer the poster boy of patriarchy



that he was. Veera is now a docile househusband who accompanies his wrestler wife, Keerthy (Aishwarya), to her matches with refreshments in hand, takes care of their school-going child, Mathi Malar (Zara Zynanna), and teaches aerobics to housewives in his neighbourhood.

Gender roles are so rigidly affixed in this world, as in ours, that the film looks at Veera's identity as a househusband through a heightened lens – it threatens the manhood of the husbands of his neighbours, causes troubles in Mathi's classroom,

has spoiled his relationship with his uncle Rathnam (Karunaas), and ends up playing a central role in the conflict that arises between him and his wife. A manipulative wrestling coach (Tarak Ponnappa), jealous of Keerthy's success, uses Veera's domestic worries to dismantle Keerthy's wrestling dreams.

How everything fits seamlessly in the narrative is what captures one's attention. In the first instalment, there's a setup surrounding a video clip that Veera's friend Sattam (Kaali Venkat) would have shot of Veera

before the wedding. Similarly, many details in *Gatta Kusthi 2* find a suitable situation for a pay-off – the most playful of which is Mathi's affinity for dancing, which recurs in a scene that left the hall in splits. One can even say that the humour in the sequel worked far better than in the first feature.

Chella Ayyavu also fixes two key blots in his material. It had infuriated one to see *Gatta Kusthi* end Keerthy's wrestling dreams ambiguously, as she vowed to make her newborn daughter a wrestling champion. Here, Keerthy not only gets all the agency that an ambitious sportswoman deserves, but the film also actually sits down with how she thrusts her dreams onto her child – Chella makes a case for both why it isn't ideal to decide for your children and why girl children need to pick up self-defence in a growingly unsafe world. Further, after failing to give Veera's aunt, Padma Rathnam (Lizzie Antony), agency and a sense of closure in the first film, Chella does well in the sequel, as she finally shows her husband his place.

Just as everything seems to be

going smoothly, a cringeworthy courtroom scene featuring Ramya Krishnan in a cameo signals what is to come. The director, once again struggling to wrap it all up, once again resorts to a couple of brain-numbingly regressive tropes. In both the *Gatta Kusthi* films, women's bodies are bafflingly used against themselves. Just ahead of their wrestling match in the first film,

Gatta Kusthi 2

Director: Chella Ayyavu

Cast: Vishnuu Vishal, Aishwarya Lekshmi

Storyline: As Veera embraces life as a stay-at-home husband, a manipulative wrestling coach drives a wedge between him and his champion wife, threatening both their marriage and her career.

Keerthy, a trained wrestler, becomes pregnant, paving the way for a heroic climax for her husband, who had trained for merely 15 days. The climax in the second film, too, is a cop-out, but two regressive ideas are thrown in the ring instead of one.

The last thirty minutes of *Gatta Kusthi 2* almost upend all the good it had done till then, and many arcs – like the fate of the nefarious coach and whether Mathi will choose wrestling – end abruptly, making one wonder if the fight will be taken to a third round. After all, the sequel has much more going for it than the first instalment, and so one can indeed expect everyone involved in the project to see the fruits of success – especially Vishnuu and Aishwarya, who have given their absolute best. Everyone will rejoice, except the film's central character, Keerthy. For all that she is put through in the film's climactic sequence, one hopes her glorious epilogue scene marks her final bow from our screens.

Gatta Kusthi 2 is currently running in theatres

Minions & Monsters

Director: Pierre Coffin

Cast: Pierre Coffin, Trey Parker, Allison Janney, Christoph Waltz, Jesse Eisenberg, Jeff Bridges, Zoey Deutch, Bobby Moynihan, Phil LaMarr

Storyline: The minions go to Hollywood, destroy tinsel town and then save it.



A yellow-blue love letter

English

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George Lucas clutching a cup of coffee inside a glass cage begging to be let off is one of those silly-smart, giggle-snort-inducing moments in *Minions & Monsters*, the third film in the *Despicable Me* prequel series.

During a film history tour with the Lucas exhibit, the tour guide, Olivia (Allison Janney), talks about James and Henry, and their important contribution to films. When the tour members reveal no knowledge of James and Henry, Olivia decides to tell them the story of how these

goggle-eyed yellow creatures ruled, ruined and raised Hollywood.

A different group of minions (not Kevin, Stuart and Bob, who are Gru's henchmen), led by Dick, sail the seven seas in search of an evil master to serve. While all the minions are happy following Dick's lead, one minion, called James, loves to paint and tell stories. He becomes fast friends with Henry. Ed, who is hard of hearing, joins the duo.

An unfortunate event involving a painting causes the minions to be banished from the Cyclops' island. Another ill-fated encounter with a spell book puts paid to their ambitions of serving an evil enchanter. After mistaking a mummy's bindings for toilet paper and other mishaps, the minions

land in 1920s Hollywood. While their brush with movies starts as a series of catastrophic events, they are soon the toast of tinsel town, living quite the movie-star life till the appearance of sound causes them to be fired since no one understands their language. James, who dreams of making a film, decides to go ahead and do just that, dusting off the old spell book to find the requisite monster. All comes right after all manner of merry mayhem.

The colours are lovely and the action frenetic. The voice work is excellent. Everyone, from director Pierre Coffin, voicing the minions, to Trey Parker as the villainous Goomi, Christoph Waltz as the film director Max, who helps the minions, Jesse Eisenberg as Dort, the alien who wants to take over the world, and Jeff Bridges as Frank and Elwood Bright, the film bros and studio bosses, inject verve into their characters.

The humour is smart and silly. Inserting the minions

into classic Hollywood scenes, from getting trapped in the assembly line with Charlie Chaplin (*Modern Times*) to hanging on the hands of the clock (*The 39 Steps*) and a façade falling down (*Steamboat Bill, Jr.*) is funny in a warm, fuzzy way. While younger audiences might not get all the Hollywood nostalgia, the visual gags are funny on their own.

The Dort story arc is sweet, from his apartment-lair to his grumpy landlady for whom he stops his world domination plans to get blueberry muffins and milk. The humour has no time to get repetitive in the brisk 90-minute running time.

The fact that we have no trouble following Minionese, the entirely made-up language the minions speak, underlines the fact that the language of cinema is truly universal.

Minions & Monsters is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Rajkummar Rao's first look from Sourav Ganguly biopic unveiled

The first look of Rajkummar Rao from his upcoming biopic on Sourav Ganguly, *Dada*, was unveiled by the makers on July 8.

The poster is a recreation of an iconic moment of Ganguly, waving his shirt in aggression after defeating England at Lord's stadium in 2002 to secure the Natwest Trophy. The poster was subtitled as, "He didn't just play the game, he changed it."

The film is directed by Vikramaditya Motwane and shot by Siddharth Diwan. More details about the plot and other cast members from the film are awaited.

Dada is produced by Luv Ranjan. It will be released in theatres on May 14, 2027.



Neha Dhupia-Adil Hussain's 52 Blue to open London Indian Film Festival

Actors Neha Dhupia and Adil Hussain's upcoming international feature film, *52 Blue*, opened the prestigious London Indian Film Festival at BFI Southbank on July 9. The film is directed by Egyptian filmmaker Ali El Arabi.

Neha Dhupia shared, "52 Blue will always be a special film for me because it marks my first international project, and to see it opening a festival as prestigious as the London Indian Film Festival feels surreal."

Notably, *52 Blue* tells the story of a young Indian man, who goes on a once-in-a-lifetime journey to realise his dream of meeting his idol, Messi, at the 2022 Football World Cup in Qatar.



Mohanlal to star in Dileesh Pothan's next directorial

In a collaboration that has thrilled fans, Mohanlal announced an upcoming project, titled *Nedumkandam Miracle*, directed by Dileesh Pothan, on July 03 via his Instagram handle.

Pennd by Syam Pushkaran and Paulson Skaria, *Nedumkandam Miracle* will be produced by Achu Baby John under the banner of John & Mary Creative. The film's distribution will be handled by Bhavana Release, co-owned by Dileesh, Syam and Fahadh Faazil.

The film boasts a lineup of proven technicians — Shyju Khalid as the cinematographer, Sushin Shyam as the composer and Saiju Sreedharan as the editor.



A brutal revisionist legend

Unrelentingly grim and gory, there is nothing merry about this dark take on history's most famous outlaw

English

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Michael Sarnoski, who helmed the multiple award-winning *Pig* and the meditative *A Quiet Place: Day One*, presents a radically different version of Sherwood Forest's famous outlaw in *The Death of Robin Hood*.

There is no rock 'n' rolla Robin Hood with Taron Egerton, Ridley Scott's magnificently staged battles featuring Russell Crowe, the Crusades and the rightness of the Merry Men's cause, Bryan Adams soulfully singing 'Everything I Do' while Kevin Costner squints meaningfully as he draws a bow or even a meandering mole, a wandering extra or a rebellious boom mike in Mel Brooks' hilarious *Men in Tights*.

Right in the beginning, an older Robin Hood (Hugh Jackman) tells a young woman, Wainwright (Jade Croot), who has sought him out, that none of the legends about him are true (no everlasting love for Maid Marian either) and that he is a brigand and murderer. Wainwright

The Death of Robin Hood

Director: Michael Sarnoski

Cast: Hugh Jackman, Jodie Comer, Bill Skarsgård, Murray Bartlett, Noah Jupe

Storyline: A gravely wounded Robin Hood goes to an island priory to recover and ruminate

turns out to have sought him out for revenge.

Robin Hood visits his friend and fellow outlaw Little John (Bill Skarsgård) who is now a farmer called Edward (he adopts the name of the man he killed) with a wife called Margaret and a daughter, Little Margaret (Faith Delaney).

In the fight to get John's farm back, Robin is gravely injured and John leaves him on the island priory of St. Clement. As he recuperates on the island, with the help of the prioress, Sister Brigid (Jodie Comer), Robin Hood thinks of his life and choices. He helps a traumatised Little Margaret, who also comes to the island, cope, teaching her how to fashion a bow and skin a rabbit.

Jackman is a towering presence as the world-weary outlaw who has seen too many things no one should have. Skarsgård and Comer give ample support while Murray Bartlett is arresting as the leper and caretaker on the island with an agenda and Noah Jupe uses his angelic good looks to conceal a traitorous heart.

Sarnoski, who has also written the film based on the 17th-Century ballad, *Robin Hood's Death*, has used the bare bones of the story to look at the truth behind the legend.

Forget all the robbing of the rich to give to the poor and nasty Nottingham, in the

film, 1247 England is a hard place to eke out a living. One almost wishes for the suspiciously clean medieval villages and the jaunty outlaws going about their merry ways instead of the unrelenting violence and gore that seem to be the daily lot of the villagers.

Animals did not have a good life either, and the film dwells in unnecessary detail on disembowelling and skinning various creatures. And there is no lack of eye trauma as it seems to be the preferred method of killing people.

Cinematographer Pat Scola, in his third collaboration with Sarnoski after *Pig* and *A Quiet Place: Day One*, has created heartbreakingly beautiful frames, especially on the island, with the sun-dappled trees, interspersed with scenes of unspeakable horror, blood, grime and gore.

The incessant grimness has a terrible beauty and moves inexorably to a state of grace where we heave a sigh of relief as Robin Hood gets his hard-won peace and Little Margaret gets her legend. And for a palate cleanser, one can always spend some time with Asneezee and his son, Ahchoo.

The Death of Robin Hood is currently running in theatres